



Chapelle Arena during the knockouts. After overpowering lesser opponents in the group stage, Sindhu succumbed to China's He Bingjiao in straight games.

In women's doubles, the contrasting duo of Ashwini Ponnappa — an epitome of experience and composure — and Tanisha Crasto, a symbol of youthful exuberance, failed to advance beyond the group stage.

The men's singles category, however, did spark some hope in this dull campaign.

Lakshya became the first Indian man to qualify for the semifinals at the Games.

While he fell short of securing a silver medal, his journey included defeating compatriot HS Prannoy. Unfortunately, Lakshya finished fourth after losing to Malaysia's Lee

Zii Jia in the bronze-medal match.

Not all was doom and gloom for Indian shuttlers in Paris.

The para badminton contingent delivered a stellar performance, bagging five medals, including one gold, clinched by Nitesh Kumar in the men's singles SL3 category.

Other medallists included Suhas Yathiraj (silver - men's singles SL4), Thulasimathi Murugesan (silver - women's singles SU5), Manisha Ramdass (bronze - women's singles SU5), and Nithya Sre Sivan (bronze - women's singles SH6).

However, the team undoubtedly missed the presence of World Champion and reigning Paralympics gold medallist Pramod Bhagat, who was ruled out of the Paris Games after being found guilty of breaching anti-doping regulations by the

**Shock exit:** Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty entered the Paris Games as firm favourites to win a medal but crashed out at the quarterfinal stage. GETTY IMAGES

Badminton World Federation (BWF).

### Youngsters on the rise

While the seniors fell short of expectations, several youngsters seized the spotlight. Early in the year, Anmol Kharb played a key role in helping the Indian women's team clinch a historic gold medal at the Badminton Asia Team Championships by defeating Thailand 3-2. The 17-year-old triumphed over Pornpicha Choeikeewong in straight games in the deciding match.

In July, Priyanshu Rajawat stunned